

FRESH CHAPTER Puja being performed for the newly opened mess at BJMC; (below) the old mess destroyed in the crash



GUJARAT

THE DAY AFTER THE SKIES FELL

This campus—BJMC—was Ground Zero for Flight 171. How students and faculty are coping with the trauma

By **Jumana Shah**

FOR DR NISHA PRAJAPATI, the sound of an airplane flying overhead every few minutes used to be a "privilege". That pure response became impossible after June 12, when Air India Flight 171 crashed into her universe: the Byramjee Jeejeebhoy Medical College (BJMC). Now, every time the sound of an aircraft taking off fills the OPD, the trauma is relived. Scared glances are momentarily exchanged. "But the moment passes, and we break out into laughter, with lame jokes about our fears. That's our coping mechanism," says Dr Prajapati.

Assistant professor of psychiatry at BJMC, she's in a good place to talk about a bad thing. "The campus is still processing grief. We talk about the tragedy all the time," she says. In the end, the body count on the ground totalled 19; four students were among them. Classes were suspended for 11 days after the incident. On June 23, 'normal' life was restarted after a prayer meet. Three days later, optional prelims exams were held; all except one student took the exam. University exams starting August 1 will continue on schedule as they believe routine will help students recover. "We expect PTSD (post traumatic stress disorder) to surface in unexpected ways in the coming months," says the doctor.

The mess destroyed by the crash served 1,500 students. In June-end, it was temporarily relocated, close to the crash site, in the boys' hostel. Again, a